

Using Reflective Practice to Inform Personal and Professional Development

Lesson 1



Developing Personally and Professionally

**Continuous
development**

**Personal
development**

**Professional
development**

Continuous Development

When you finish your formal education, it doesn't mean that it's the end of the journey and you have to stop learning.

You'll continue to accrue knowledge and skills as you progress through your life and career, in a process referred to as continuous development.

Also known as lifelong learning, continuous development has been defined by the Department for Education as the 'ongoing, voluntary and self-motivated pursuit of knowledge for either personal or professional reasons'.

Personal and Professional Development

Personal and professional development may seem distinct from each other, but developing personally will influence how you approach work, and developing professionally will in turn promote personal growth.

Development will occur in a variety of ways. It could be formal and planned, such as completing this qualification. Alternatively, it could come about more by chance, through being put in a situation that presents new opportunities or challenges.

Benefits of Continuous Development

There are numerous benefits that could be gained from engaging in continuous development. For example, you may be better placed for progression in your current role or for new job opportunities. By taking charge of your personal and professional development, you can tailor your skills to the career direction you want to take.

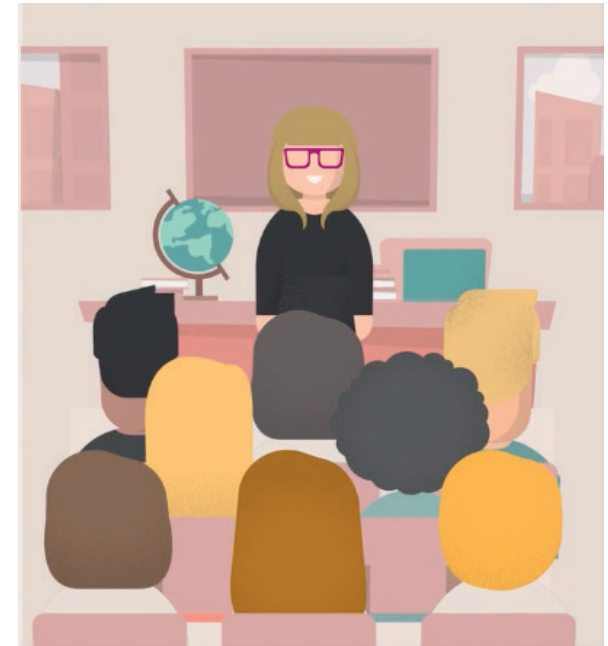
This can give you an edge in the hunt for that special job - when recruiting new staff, employers like to see that job applicants have kept their skills up to date. In fact, to evidence continuous development, a useful tip is to add two new items to your CV each year.



Benefits of Continuous Development (cont.)

While continuous development may put you ahead of the field of job applicants, it can also offer longer-term employment benefits such as higher pay, more progression and more sustained employment.

Learning can also be transformational, as the winner of a Learning and Work Institute award found. Fiona Pickett thought that she would never teach again after losing her hearing. However she retrained as a lip-reading tutor, and went on to train 70 other lip-reading tutors, transforming the lives of hundreds of people facing similar challenges.



Benefits of Continuous Development (cont.)

Organisations, too, see the benefits of continuous development.

Recent research by IT consultants Gartner has shown that in today's competitive business environment having static skills in the workforce won't be enough to remain competitive.

To address this, many companies now foster a development culture to keep ahead of the competition.

Reflective Practice

So where does reflective practice fit into continuous development and the development culture?

Reflective practice is a form of learning that's ideally suited to personal and professional development. It's a process of examining past events as a way to develop future practice.

Author Peter Lucas says it 'involves a systematic enquiry to improve and deepen our understanding of our own practice.' Barbara Bassot, a prominent author in this area, says that this enquiry 'includes questioning what you do, engaging with your feelings and gaining greater self-awareness.'

In this unit, the terms reflection and reflective practice will be used interchangeably. Sometimes 'reflection' is used to refer to the less formal action of looking back on events, but here it will be used to describe the more structured and formal approach of reflective practice.

Improving Self-awareness

American Professor Donald Schön is often associated with the development of reflective practice. In his 1983 book, he suggested that reflecting on practice means engaging in the process of continuous learning, and that it is one of the defining characteristics of professional practice.

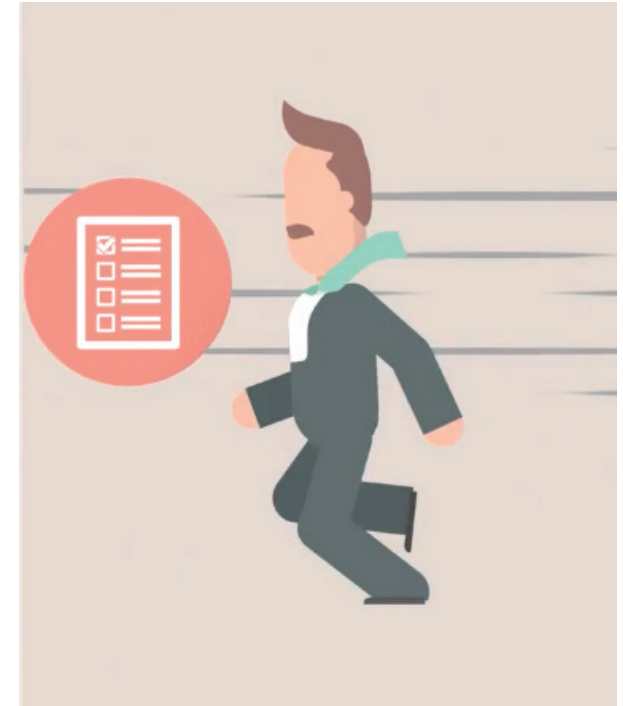
While you might not be familiar with reflection, or be rather wary of it, reflective practice is a valuable learning process and could offer you a number of benefits.

One key benefit is the improvement of your self-awareness. This means gaining a better understanding of your own attitudes and values, and how they influence your behaviour in and outside work.

Avoiding Mistakes

Reflection may also lead you to question your assumptions and help you to avoid mistakes in the future.

A manager's life can be fast-paced and hectic, and will likely require quick decision-making. Reflection entails taking time to examine what happened as a result of your decisions, and considering why it happened.



Learning Through Experience

It provides an ongoing picture of your practice and may stimulate some creativity in your approach, so you can improve the way you work.

As academic David Boud argues, reflection is at the core of learning through experience: without the process of reflection, experience will remain experience and learning won't be realised.

So having established an understanding of continuous development and the role that reflective practice takes, next we'll focus on personal development more closely.

Focussing on Personal Development

So far, we've learned about the benefits of continuous development, and identified that personal development will progress your professional development, and vice versa.

In this part of the lesson we're going to focus expressly on personal development.

Your Value

Personal development can be seen as a way to boost your human capital. This is defined as a measure of the education, skills, experience and attributes that will influence your contribution and potential in the employment market and beyond. Another way of describing this is your **value**.

Harvard professor Howard Gardner emphasises that there isn't only one dimension to human capital. For example, a highly educated person might at the same time be a poor manager, or a successful entrepreneur may have little formal education.



Growth and Discovery

The focus of personal development is growth, and its foundation is widening the discovery of your own character and capabilities. It's also about improving strengths and talents and building future potential.

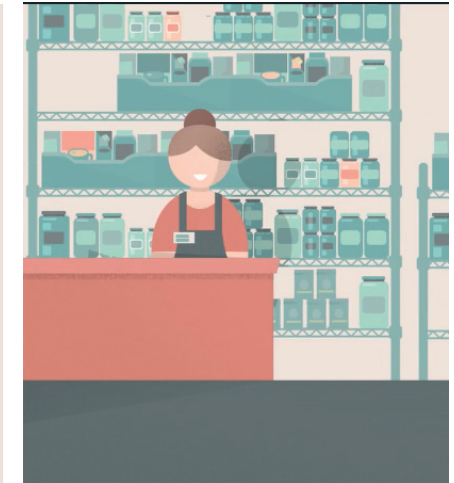
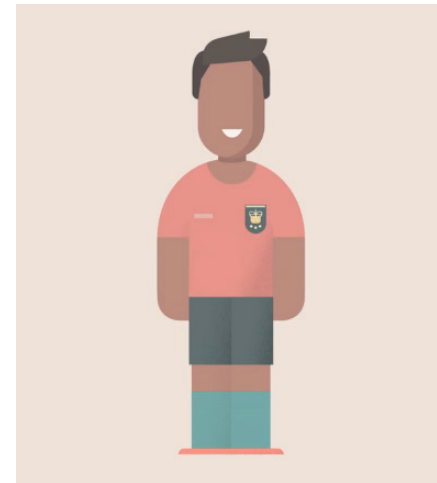
Personal development can also relate to the development of others; this is particularly relevant in management, where you might train, coach or mentor team members.

Indirect Benefits of Personal Development

The direct benefits of personal development to your immediate work role will not always be apparent, but it will likely offer some indirect benefits through the transfer of new skills and knowledge.

For example, the skills developed as captain of the junior football league would show a strong correlation with those needed for any team leader at work.

While volunteering for the local food bank may not seem so relevant, planning and organisation skills are required, and it could also heighten diversity awareness and personal empathy.



Organisations and Personal Development

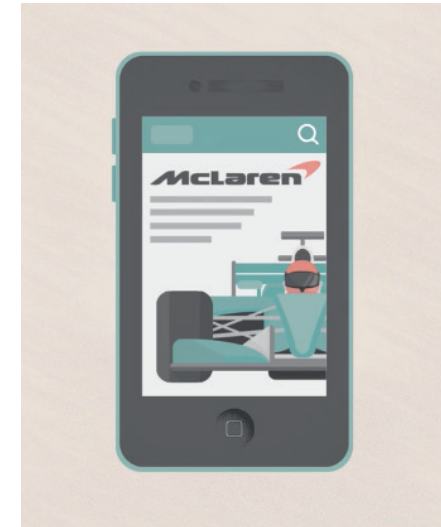
Organisations have also picked up on the importance of personal development.

For example, research carried out by motorsport company McLaren found that personal development was the most important employment factor for those aged 18 to 24 and 25 to 34 – key generations it wanted to attract to its talent pipeline.

Organisations and Personal Development (cont.)

On the back of this, McLaren developed a mobile learning platform, which encouraged social networking and learning discussions in real time, and it also developed mentoring opportunities with McLaren business leaders.

Tech giant Microsoft set up 'The Garage' to encourage and develop problem solving in new and innovative ways, empowering people to achieve more. It's made up of four interconnected programmes that support different stages of personal and project development.



Personal Investment

So having identified that personal development is about improved self-knowledge and strength building, we can start to see that these things are best developed through experience.

Personal development should always be considered a journey rather than a destination. While the process itself is not complicated, it will need some investment from you to enable you to better understand your current strengths, areas needing improvement and new opportunities. It's about taking responsibility for your own learning and for choosing the means to achieve this.

Self-diagnosis

To discover more about ourselves, and to capture and learn from experience, there needs to be some form of self-diagnosis. This is a way of identifying where you are on your journey and what you need to do to get where you want to be.

Of course, we can't always accurately predict the direction that our future will take.

While world-famous author JK Rowling had ambitions to be a writer, her early career involved working for Amnesty International and the Chamber of Commerce. It was only when she was stuck on a very long train journey between Manchester and London, that the idea was born for a story about a boy attending a school of wizardry. And the rest, we can say, is history.



Self-diagnosis (cont.)

As we progress through the unit, we'll be looking at some reflective practice models that will help you in your personal development journey. We'll also examine a range of diagnostic tools that you can use to enhance self-awareness.

But next, we'll turn our attention to the parallel strand of continuous development – professional development.

Being Professional

Having spent a little time thinking about personal development, in this part of the lesson, we're going to look at how we might develop professionally.

Firstly, let's think about what it means to be professional.

A professional can be defined as someone who belongs to a distinct profession through their qualification or practice, and whose competence can usually be measured against established standards. For example, to reach Qualified Teacher Status, or QTS, a teacher must meet 8 published standards, which define the minimum level of practice expected.

Approaching Your Professional Duties

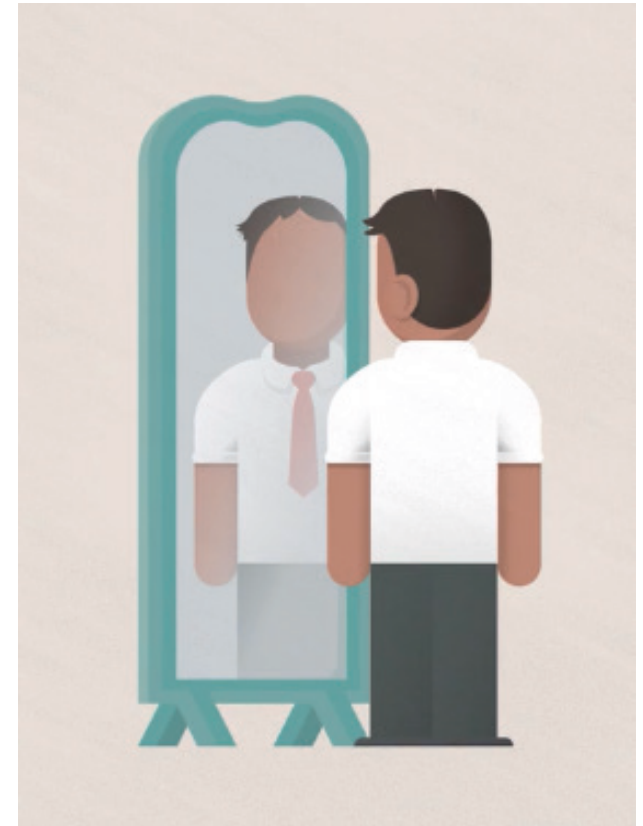
However, being professional is not just about what you do, it's also about how you do it. It's about the way you approach your professional duties, and how that approach influences the relationships between yourself and those who report to you, and to whom you report.

In fact, professor of education Judith Sachs stated that 'across society, professionalism increasingly refers to an individual's attitude and behaviour, rather than a group's formal status and collective identity.'

Reflecting on Your Practice

In their research, Sara Smith and Jan Martin illustrated that being professional is strongly associated with reflective practice and lifelong learning. They argue that it is unsustainable for individuals to keep developing themselves without having the skills of reflection.

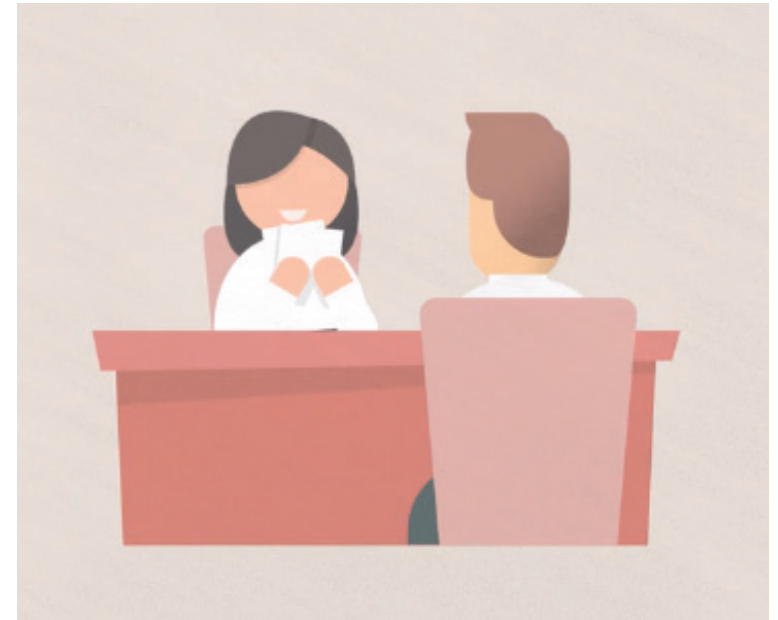
Author Peter Tarrant asserts that to develop as professionals, you need to be able to reflect on your practice and learn from this reflection. This process will make you more self-aware and more able to see your strengths and development needs.



Gaining Skills and Qualifications

Professional development can be defined as the acquisition of knowledge and skills that directly relate to your current or future professional role.

This could involve completing an occupational qualification, or gaining professional status, such as CMI Chartered Manager, or it may mean acquiring job-related skills, for example, via Higher Apprenticeship.



Professional Development and CPD

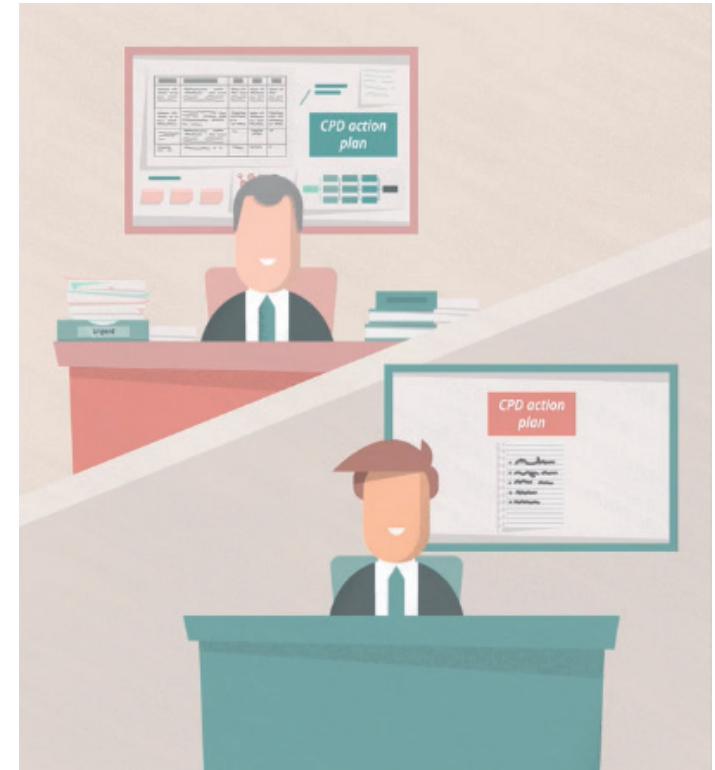
These days, the term professional development is synonymous with Continuing Professional Development, or CPD. This will particularly be the case when your development is linked to accreditation from a professional body, such as the CMI.

According to author Eugene Sadler-Smith and colleagues, CPD involves maintaining and updating current skills, strengthening levels of competence and enhancing future job and career mobility.

Your Personal Starting Point

In practice, your CPD will be unique to you, and your growth will be measured from your personal starting point, rather than referencing an imposed, external target.

A CPD plan for an established manager would look very different to that of a new graduate starting out in their first management role.



Employer Benefits of CPD

The employer can benefit from employee CPD too. CPD places responsibility for development on the individual, and can help encourage employees to keep their knowledge, skills and experience up to date.

It may also contribute to improved staff retention, because it can open up new opportunities to contribute and collaborate, and work may become more interesting.

CPD can also support succession planning for key posts, as employers can use it to focus on developing the necessary skills and experience within individual employees.

Building a Picture of Your Progress

Carrying out CPD is about much more than simply attending a few courses each year or completing a handful of training exercises; it's about being actively and constantly aware of how you can learn and develop new skills.

As you go through the CPD process over time, your attainments, performance and learning will build a picture of your progress as a management professional.

Building a Picture of Your Progress

This includes your CMI programme of study; as part of your course, you'll need to have a written CPD plan, and a way to capture and record the activities you've undertaken. We'll be covering this recording and planning process later in the unit.

So we've learned about the concept of continuous development and introduced how reflective practice can support both personal and professional development.

In the next lesson, we will be looking at reflective practice more closely, including some frameworks which can help you to structure the process of reflection.

Recap

In this lesson, you have learned about:

- Continuous development
- Personal development
- Professional development